Socialist Republican Association] including Bhagat Singh and B.K. Dutt, with conspiracy against the government,'[6] from that time onwards '[t]he popularity of the accused in the Lahore Conspiracy Case, including Bhagat Singh and Jatindranath Das, has been a controversy to many scholars'.[7] However, she argues that it was actually 'the hunger strike which the accused undertook during their trial [which] was instrumental in establishing these men in the nationalist pantheon'.[8] There were three reasons for this.

First, she states, the hunger strike and the trial provided the HSRA 'with a stage from which they could display their charismatic defiance of British authority to a larger public'. Second, the case was prosecuted 'at a time when the Indian National Congress was preparing for another nation-wide anti-British campaign' so that 'many Congressmen were drawn to support the hunger strike'. Third, that 'when Jatin Dass succumbed during the strike, and Bhagat Singh, Shivram Rajguru and Sukh Dev were executed after the trial, they provided the nationalist with martyrs to Mother India'. This was of huge significance because, '[i]n nationalist movements in which few prominent figures gave their lives, the symbolic value of the martyrdom of these four men was incalculable'. She argues that '[a]s a result, the hunger strike was woven into the larger political choreography of the nationalist movement'.[9]

However, as is clear from Taylor Sherman's own valuable analysis, it was not just the 'hunger strike' which was woven into the larger political choreography of the times, but the execution by hanging of Bhagat Singh and his two comrades. In fact, it was the execution which was the more dramatic of the two. The execution, precisely because of its coercive legal machinations, imprinted itself indelibly on the consciousness of the people of the subcontinent, and it did so for generations to come. As Taylor Sherman puts it only too well, 'The trial thus became a showcase for the defiance and bravery of the accused.' She continues, 'Newspapers conveyed the many ways in which the revolutionaries, though weakened by their fast, were able to undermine the authority of the magistrate.'[10] Chris Moffat refers to Bhagat Singh's 'uncommon passion' and explains that rather than